

Coverstory **HIGHER EDUCATION**

and a multiplicity of agencies have seen higher education stagnate and corruption become institutionalised.

FACT8: In 50 years, only 44 private institutions were granted deemed university status by the University Grants Commission. In the last five years, it has granted that status to 49 more, leading to charges of impropriety.

FACT9: The shortage of good institutions has seen cut-off percentages for entry into good colleges soar to genius

home. Yet the government drags its feet over permitting foreign universities to set up shop in India.

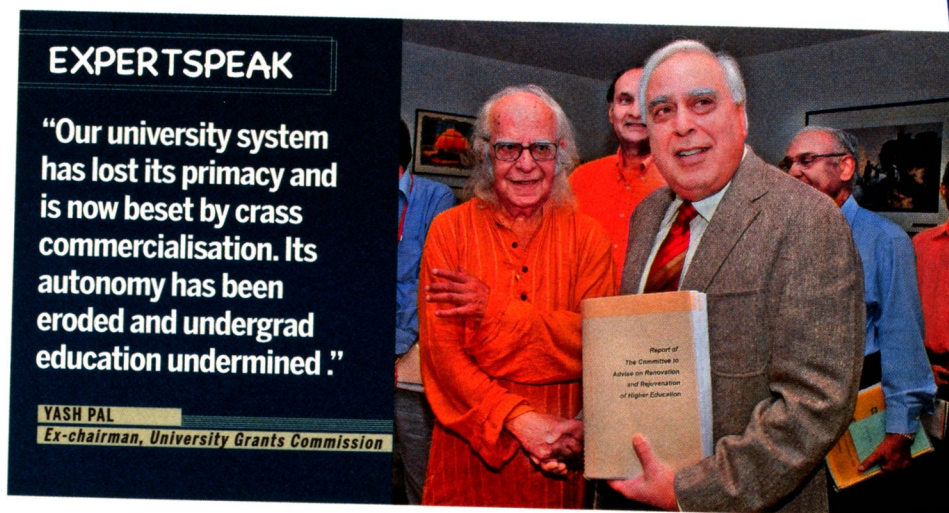
FACT12: The quality of school education hasn't improved. A recent study found that in rural north India on an average day, there is no teaching activity in about half of the primary schools.

Why Bother?

Brilliant! It's good to know what exactly India is missing out on because of all this apathy and sloth. Over a

the *maharishi* of India's telecom sector and chairman, National Knowledge Commission (NKC), declared, "Knowledge is now driving the global economy, growth, wealth creation and prosperity." (see guest column)

Everyone agrees that the quality of higher education will play a key role in India's quest to emerge as a major world power. N.R. Narayana Murthy, chairman of Infosys, points out that the American education system helped "seed the growth" of key new



SIBAL RECEIVES A COPY OF THE EXPERT REPORT FROM YASH PAL

levels. This year's qualifying marks for B.Com (Hons) course in Delhi's SRCC was 98.75 per cent.

FACT10: Studies show that the number of students committing suicide because of the pressure to perform well in secondary board exams is rising alarmingly.

FACT11: Indian students now spend \$7 billion to go abroad and study in foreign universities because of the poor quality of education at

decade ago management guru Peter Drucker had declared: "The Knowledge Society will become far more competitive than any society we have yet known... there will be no poor countries, there will only be ignorant countries... thus the competitive position of every country, industry, institution and individual will depend on the ability to harness and capitalise on knowledge." More recently Sam Pitroda,

technology industries in the US such as the semi-conductor, information technology and biotechnology through research done in its universities. The US currently accounts for over a third of the entire world's output of articles in science and engineering. India, in contrast, accounts for less than 3 per cent of research papers published and in terms of citations barely 1 per cent.

Then there is what

Nandan Nilekani, the chairman of the new Unique Identification Authority of India, calls the demographic dividend that India needs to cash in on. Almost half of the country's population is below 25 years. Almost 10 per cent of them or 12 crore are between the ages of 18 and 23. If they are equipped with both knowledge and skills, they could drive India's entrepreneurial and competitive spirit and make

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Note: GER is the 18-23 and